



Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

LANDO NORRIS CROWNED F1 WORLD CHAMPION IN ABU DHABI

McLaren's Lando Norris just needed to be on the podium at the season-ending Abu Dhabi Grand Prix at the Yas Marina Circuit yesterday to win his first Formula 1 World Championship and the 26-year-old British driver did exactly that, as he finished third behind teammate Oscar Piastri and race winner Red Bull's Max Verstappen, who saw his dream of winning a fifth straight world title come undone by just two points in the end.

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Goa club fire kills 25; GM held, owner flees

INITIAL PROBE SUGGESTS FIRE CAUSED BY CYLINDER BLAST

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

A late-night blaze at a popular nightclub in Goa has killed at least 25 people — including tourists and migrant workers — and raised urgent questions over fire safety, illegal construction and regulatory failures in one of India's busiest party belts.

The fire broke out post midnight (Saturday-Sunday) at Birch by Romeo Lane, a nightclub in Arpora village, some 25km from state capital Panaji. District officials said the venue was operating without proper permissions and with a narrow entry and exit, which hampered rescue efforts.

Chief Minister Pramod Sawant, who visited the site early yesterday morning, confirmed that the nightclub's general manager has been arrested and that an arrest warrant has been issued against the owner. A magisterial inquiry has been ordered.

Cylinder blast or fireworks?

The preliminary probe suggests that the fire was caused by a cylinder blast. A tourist who survived the incident, however, claimed that fireworks set off during a live performance triggered the blaze. Several other factors,

GOA CLUB FIRE AT A GLANCE



1 **Victims:** Tourists, kitchen staff, migrant workers (including from Jharkhand & Assam).

2 **Arrests:** GM arrested; owner absconding, warrant issued.

3 **Illegality:** Shack linked to promoters sealed; alleged construction on govt land.

4 **Safety lapses:** Narrow exit, violation of fire regulations, operation without permits.

such as the structure itself which was constructed with flammable material, and only a narrow access route and restricted escape paths made the tragedy worse. The nightclub's remote backwater location meant there was only a single narrow approach road, forcing fire engines to halt nearly 400 metres away and delaying both rescue and containment.

Officials said most deaths were due to suffocation, with three people suffering severe burns. Among the dead were four tourists, as well as many kitchen staff and migrant workers from Jharkhand and Assam.

Several witnesses said the fire seemed to originate on the first floor, which is the packed dance area where roughly 100 tourists were present. "There was a sud-

den commotion as the flames started erupting. We rushed out of the club only to see that the entire structure was up in flames," Fatima Shaikh, a tourist from Hyderabad recalled, reported news agency PTI. She was also on the dance floor and added that the palm-leaf temporary construction "easily caught fire." Many victims, witnesses said, ran downstairs during the chaos and got trapped in the kitchen along with staff members.

Authorities have sealed a beach shack in nearby Vagator operated by the nightclub's promoters, saying it was constructed illegally on government land. Officials said earlier demolition notices had been rolled back by "higher authorities."

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